

NURTURING POTENTIAL

Keep the door open.

Helping every young person succeed in second level — and
navigate what comes after.

AN IRISH POST-PRIMARY WORKSHOP · TEACHERS, YEAR HEADS & LEADERS

START HERE

Before the data, a person.

A story from inside the system.

Who changed your odds?

01

Who noticed?

Who saw more than the label, the result or the difficult week?

02

What repeated?

What did they keep doing — quietly, reliably, more than once?

03

What opened?

Which choice, confidence or future became easier to imagine?

Think privately. If invited, share the practice — not the person.

One in seven.

13.8%

of children lived in households experiencing child-specific enforced deprivation in 2024.

54.2%

where no adult in the home works

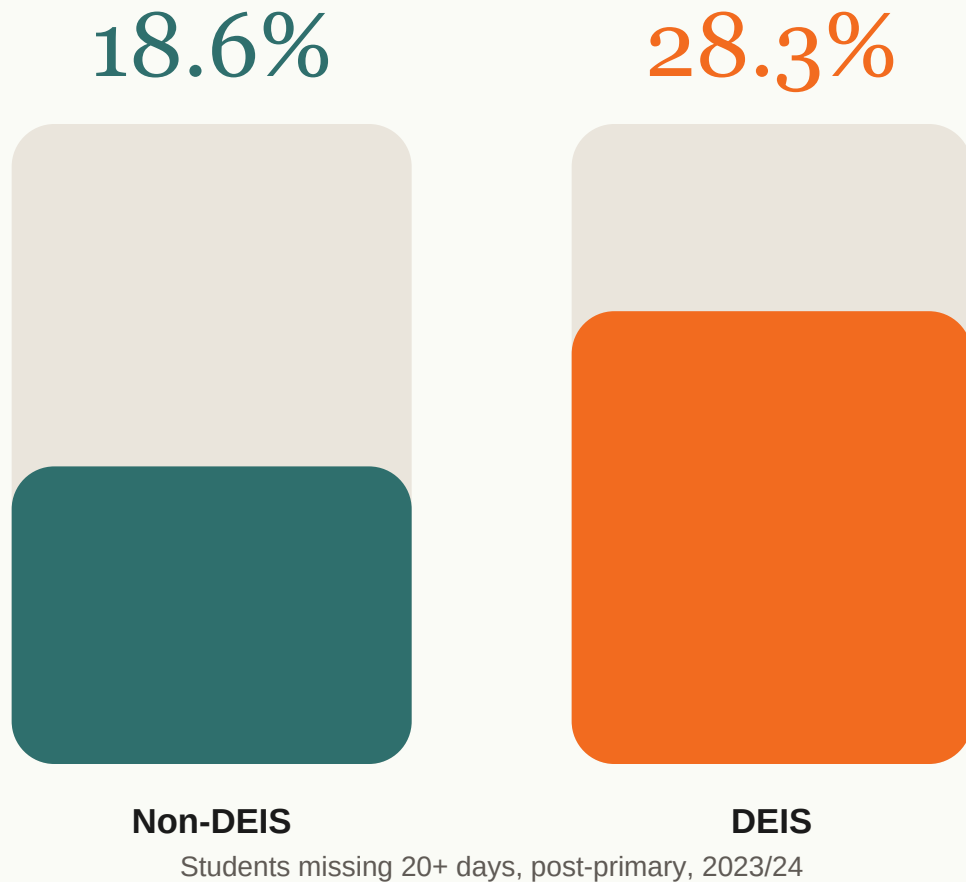
3.7%

where two adults work

The measure: a household could not afford at least three of 17 child-specific essentials or activities.

It describes the conditions around a childhood — never a child's capacity.

Absence compounds quietly.



THE REPORTED GAP

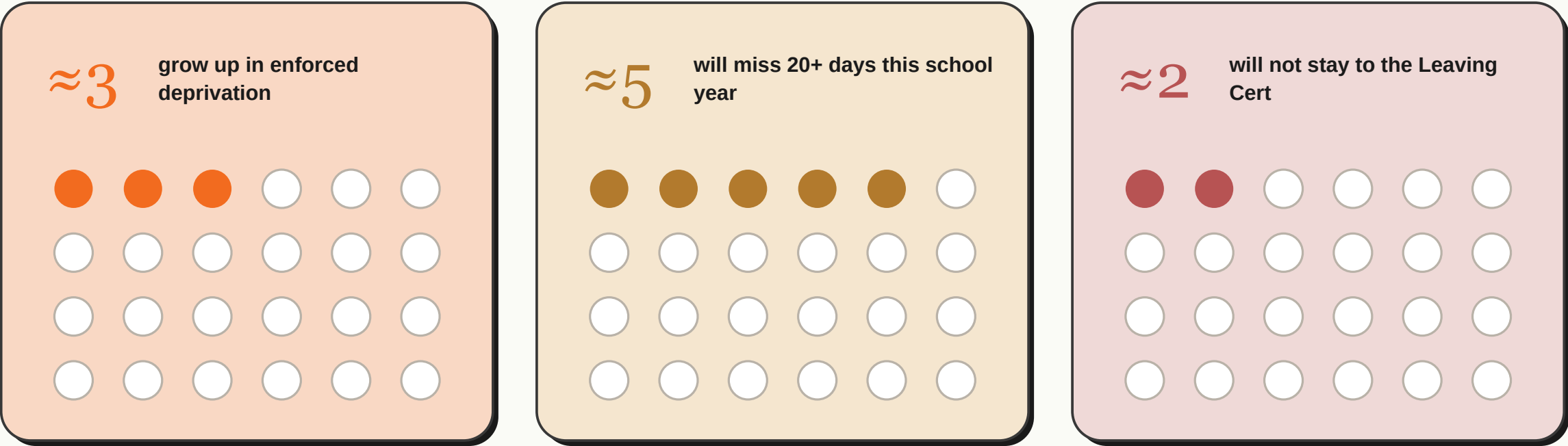
9.7 percentage points
separate the two attendance rates.

20+ days ≈ four school weeks.

Support should begin when the pattern emerges —
not at the threshold.

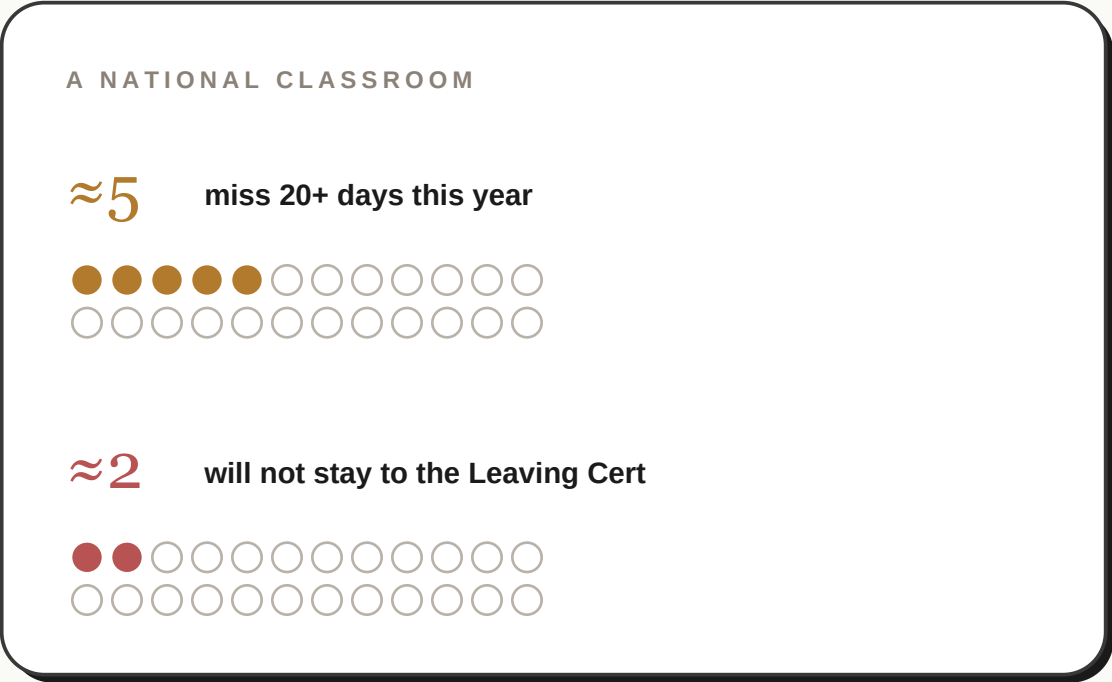
Picture one classroom.

National rates, applied to one class of 24.



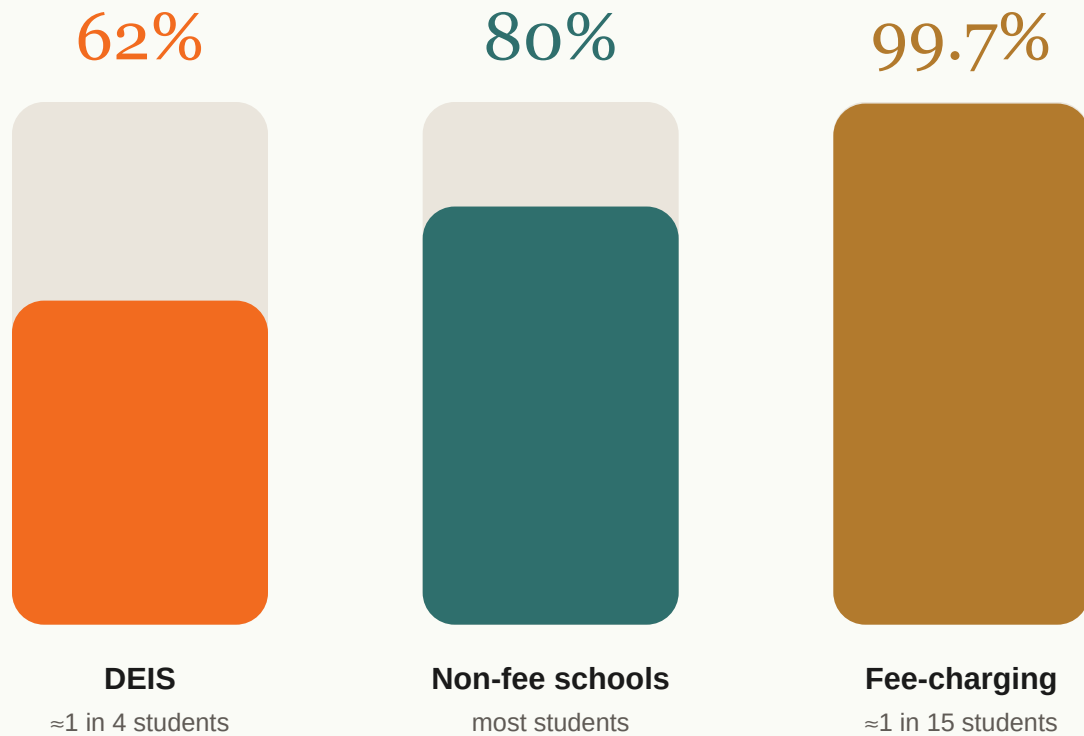
Same room, same teacher, same timetable — **very different starting lines.**

Now make it a DEIS classroom.



Same promise needed. **Twice the weight on it.**

Same exam. Three different trajectories.



Progression to third level, by school type

THEN THE DESTINATION SPLITS AGAIN

Of those who do progress, the kind of third level diverges sharply by postcode:

Dublin 4	75.6%	go to a university
Dublin 10	17.6%	go to a university

A door, then a corridor — both narrower from a disadvantaged start.

Background shifts the odds. It does not write the outcome.

74

maths points separated Ireland's most and least socio-economically advantaged quarters in PISA 2022.

12%

of disadvantaged students were academically resilient — scoring in Ireland's top quarter.

Ireland's gap is smaller than the OECD average (93 points) — **and it narrowed between 2012 and 2022.**

The route into higher education is uneven.

THE NAVIGATION GAP

Routes need
equal visibility.

01 Points / CAO

02 FET / PLC

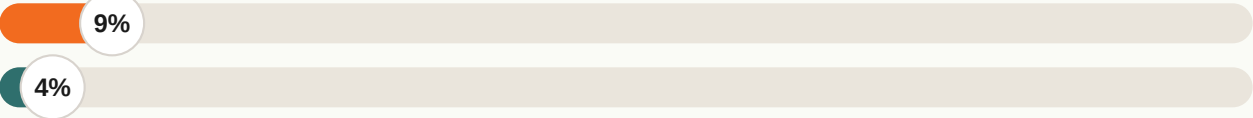
03 Mature / HEAR

Different routes are not lesser.

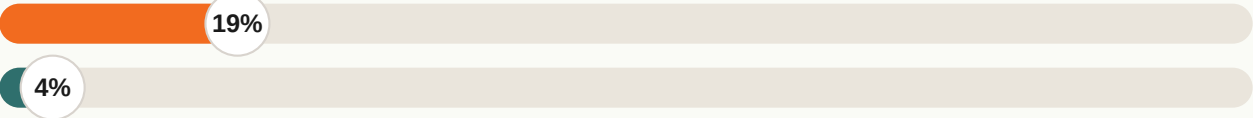
Second-level exams



FET award



Mature + HEAR



Disadvantaged entrants

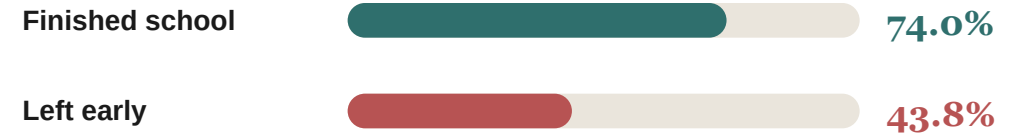
Affluent entrants

The price of a closed door.

3×

more likely to be unemployed at 18–24: early school leavers, compared with peers who finished.

IN EMPLOYMENT, AGE 18–24

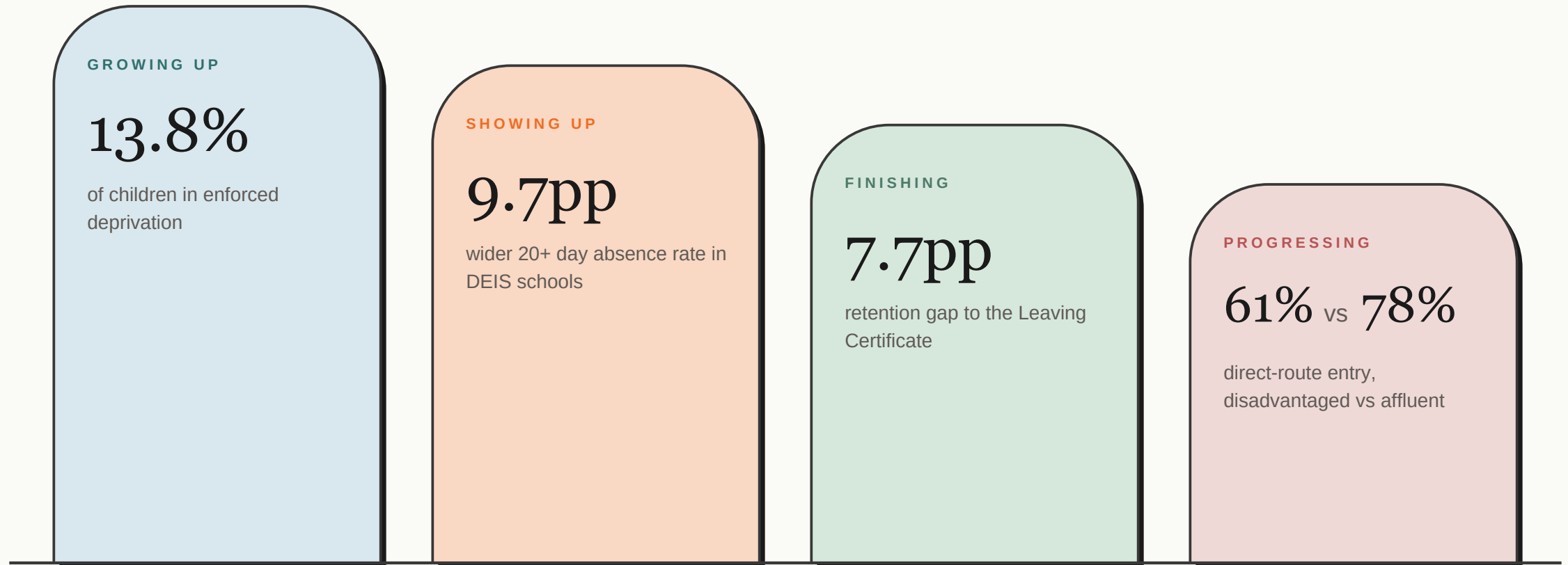


6,406 students

who started second level in 2018 did not finish — and most slipped away during senior cycle.

Keeping the door open is an economic intervention — not only a kindness.

Not one wall. Four quiet doors.



Four separate national measures. One direction of travel. Each door can be held open — that is the rest of this workshop.

Data can sharpen action — or harden a stereotype.

THE QUICK CONCLUSION

“They do not value school.”

“The family will not engage.”

“Not college material.”

“Trauma explains the behaviour.”

THE USEFUL QUESTION

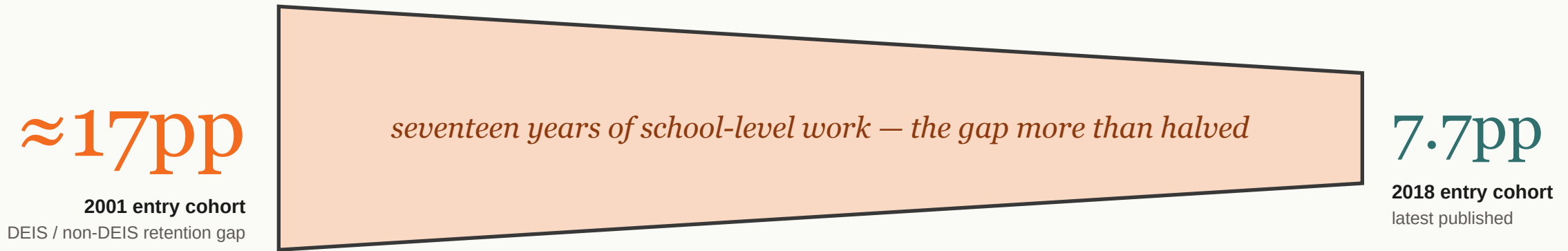
“What makes attendance harder here?”

“How accessible and trustworthy is our contact?”

“Which routes and supports are still invisible?”

“What supports regulation and a return to learning?”

Progress is real. The remaining gap is real.



2018 entry cohort: DEIS 84.1% · non-DEIS 91.8% stayed to the Leaving Certificate.

PISA tells the same story: **Ireland's socio-economic gap in maths narrowed between 2012 and 2022.**

In the door is not up the stairs.

Keeping students in school is being won. What happens after is the new gap.

FIRST YEAR IN COLLEGE

23% vs 12%

of disadvantaged entrants do not progress past first year — nearly double the affluent rate.

COURSE CHOICE

High-points courses

Medicine, engineering and finance are dominated by entrants from affluent backgrounds.

Aspiration needs points — and navigation.

AFTER GRADUATION

14% vs 24%

go on to postgraduate study; graduate unemployment runs 9% against 6%.

Access is not the finish line. Progression, completion and course choice are the next door.

The adult is the variable.

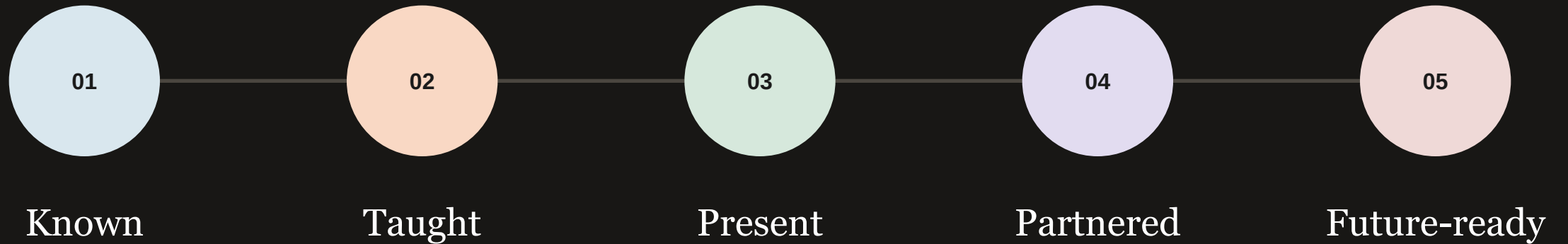
WHAT THE IRISH EVIDENCE POINTS TO

Students who grew up economically vulnerable needed positive teacher relationships in early secondary school to reach the same attainment as better-off peers — even when their parents held high expectations.

Growing Up in Ireland '98 cohort, ~8,500 young people followed from age 9 to 20.

The relationship is not the soft part of the job. It is the mechanism.

Five promises that change the odds.



Not five programmes. Five dependable experiences of school.

Relationships are learning infrastructure.

THE PROMISE

Every student is known by name,
noticed early and met with
strengths first.

School cannot remove every external pressure. **It can make sure no student becomes invisible.**

01 Name

One reliable adult the student can identify.

02 Notice

Absence, withdrawal and change trigger contact.

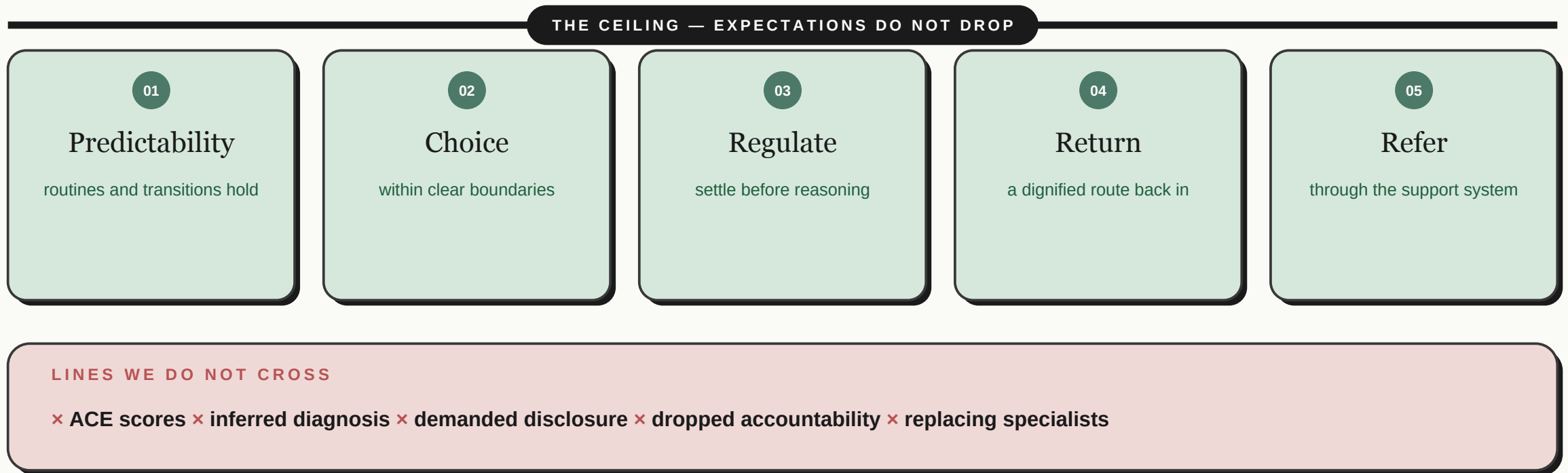
03 Repair

Conflict has a dignified route back to learning.

04 Record

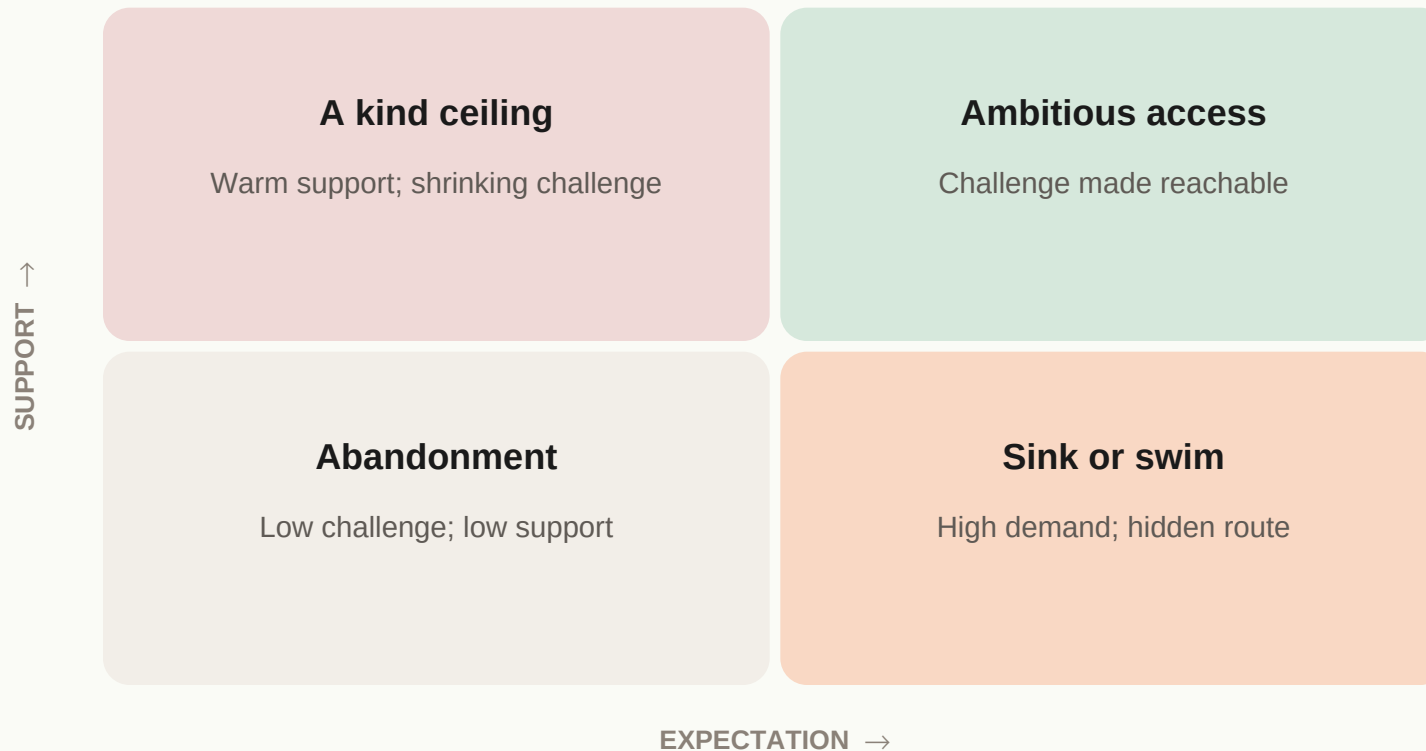
Support begins with strengths and what works.

Care without lowering the ceiling.



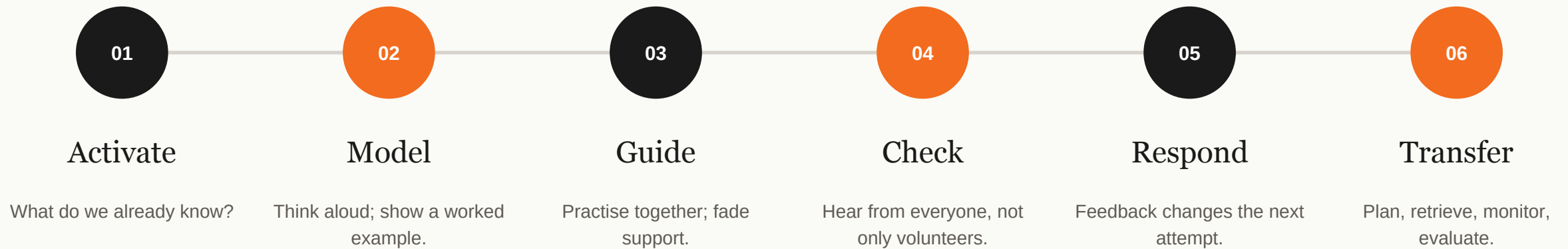
Respond to what is observable. Refer what is not ours to assess.

High expectations need high support.



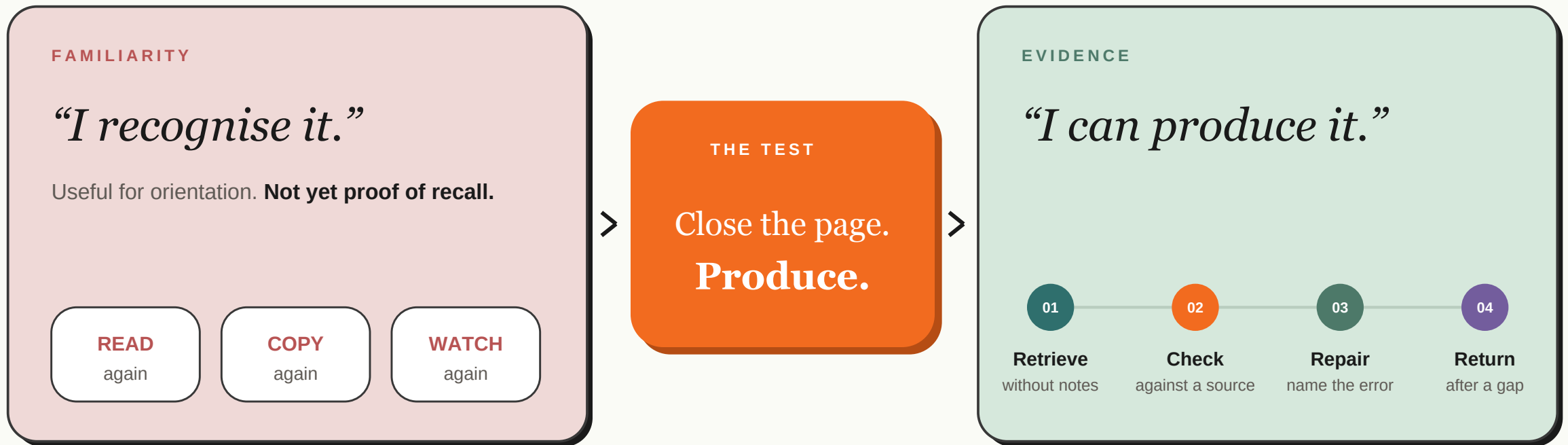
The goal is not “be tougher.” The goal is to make ambitious work **legible, scaffolded and attainable.**

Teach the route, not only the destination.



Metacognition works best inside subject teaching: model how an expert plans, monitors and evaluates a real task.

Studying is not the same as learning.



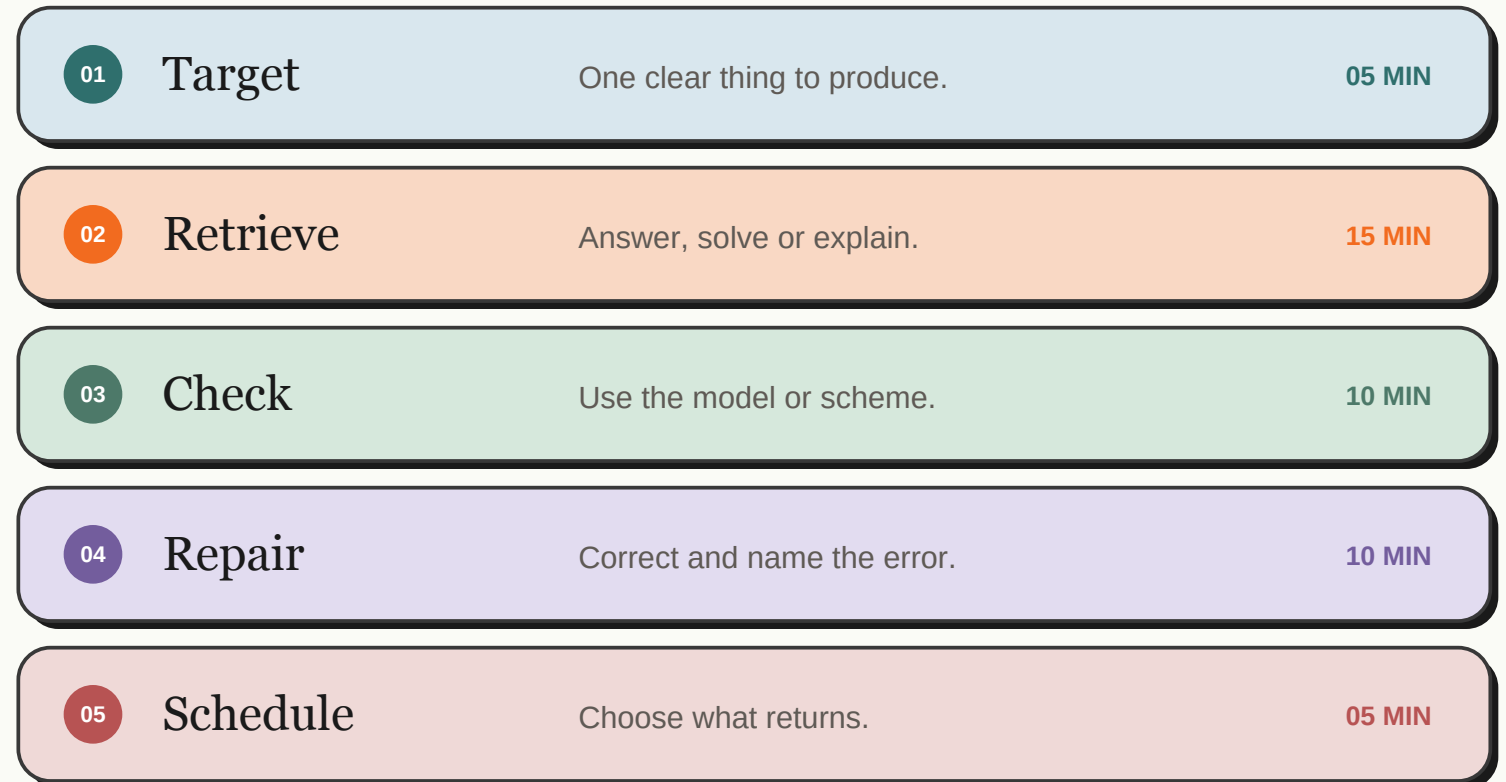
Input can orient. Evidence shows what survived when the page disappeared.

A study session needs an ending, not just a timer.

ONE PRACTICAL SHAPE

45
MINUTES

The time can flex. **The sequence cannot.**



Do not make success depend on a quiet bedroom.

THE EQUITY TEST

Could the student use this method without private tuition, their own device or an expert adult at home?

If not, access is the gap —
and access is part of pedagogy.

WHAT SCHOOL CAN MAKE DEPENDABLE

01

A supervised study slot

predictable, timetabled, staffed

02

Device, print and scheme access

nothing hinges on home kit

03

A modelled routine

built on real subject work

04

A low-noise place to practise

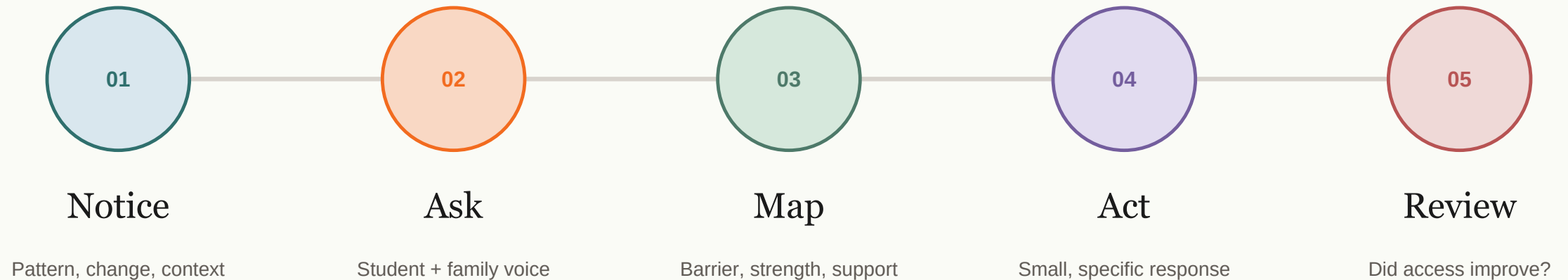
retrieval needs quiet, not luck

05

Rapid feedback

plus one visible next step

20 days is a reporting threshold. Support starts sooner.



Use days missed, not only percentages. Be specific. Stay curious about the cause.

Partnership is designed before it is declared.

FIVE HABITS THAT MAKE CONTACT REACHABLE

01

Specific

days · patterns · next step

02

Curious

ask before interpreting

03

Strength-first

name what the child can do

04

Accessible

person · language · channel · time

05

Reliable

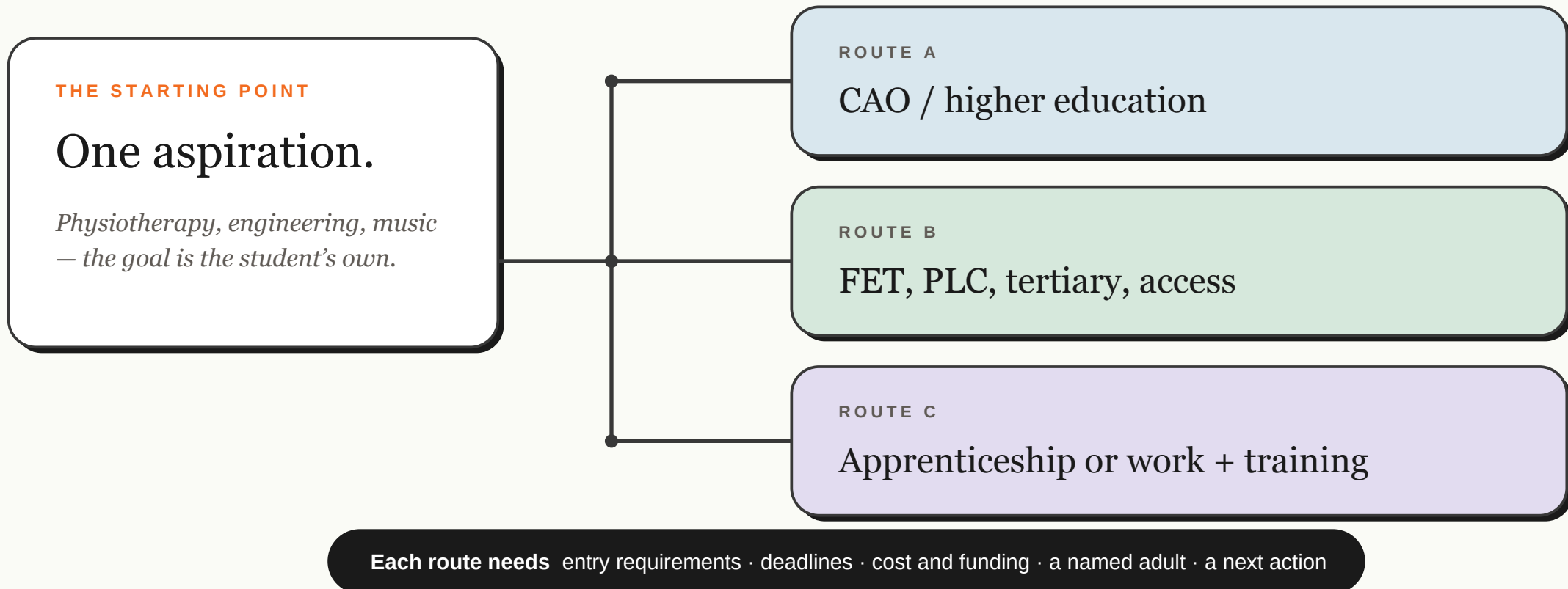
do what was agreed · report back

A STRONGER FIRST CONTACT

“We have missed Sam on seven mornings. Sam’s oral answers in Science are strong. Is transport, sleep, caring, anxiety — or something else — making mornings harder?”

“Can we agree one step and check in on Friday?”

A pathway is only real when a student can navigate it.



Leah is capable. School is becoming harder to reach.

LEAH • FIFTH YEAR

Strong oral contributions. Written work is inconsistent. Sixteen days absent by February and often late. She helps care for younger siblings. She says she wants physiotherapy, then adds: “Courses like that are for people with money.”

IN GROUPS

01

What might the school wrongly infer?

02

What do we need to learn from Leah and home?

03

What changes tomorrow, this term, this year?

04

Who owns each next step?

Coordinate the supports around the student.

01 Known

Named check-in; ask Leah what is changing and what helps.

02 Taught

Model written responses; prioritised catch-up after absence.

03 Present

Map caring/morning barriers; agree a small plan; review weekly.

04 Partnered

Strength-first family conversation; practical constraints first.

05 Future-ready

Physio Route A; related FET/tertiary Route B; funding + HEAR check.

Shared · sequenced · reviewed. One owner, one next step, one date to learn.

Six strategies that survive contact with an exam.

01 Retrieval practice

Produce from memory first; check second. The single biggest upgrade.

IN THE APP · STUDY SESSIONS · MARK BANK

02 Spaced practice

Short returns over weeks beat one long cram.

IN THE APP · SPACED REPETITION TIMETABLE

03 Interleaving

Mix question types so choosing the method is part of practice.

IN THE APP · MIXED MARK BANK REVIEWS

04 Worked examples

Study the route before walking it alone.

IN THE APP · MODULES MODEL EACH METHOD

05 Command words

Answer the verb: define, contrast, evaluate.

IN THE APP · COMMAND-WORD REFLEX

06 Mark like an examiner

Check against the real scheme; name the repair.

IN THE APP · MARK BANK · PAPER TRAIL

Ask yourself before the notes open.

01 ASK

from today's class

“What are the two effects of spaced practice?”

02 ANSWER FROM MEMORY

the notes stay closed

say it • write it • sketch it

03 ONLY THEN, CHECK

now the notes open

keep it — or repair it by name

HOW A STUDENT RUNS IT

01 After class: write three questions — not a summary.

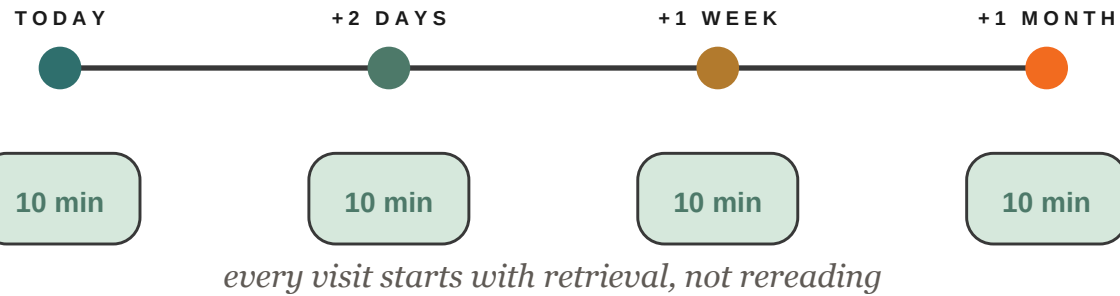
02 Next day: answer them closed-book, aloud or on paper.

03 Open the notes only after answering: keep, or repair.

Reading feels easy. Retrieval feels hard — the difficulty is the signal it works.

Four short visits beat one long night.

FOUR SHORT VISITS



✗ **one 40-minute cram, the night before** *same minutes · weaker memory*

HOW A STUDENT RUNS IT

- 01 Finish a topic? Book its returns: 2 days · 1 week · 1 month.
- 02 Every visit starts with retrieval, not rereading.
- 03 Ten focused minutes counts as a full visit.

In the app: the Spaced Repetition Timetable books the returns automatically.

Mix the questions — choosing is the skill.

BLOCKED PRACTICE



feels smooth — fades fast

INTERLEAVED PRACTICE



feels harder — sticks

Every switch forces the question: which method fits here?

HOW A STUDENT RUNS IT

- 01 Build practice sets from three topics, shuffled.
- 02 Before solving, name which method fits — that is the rep.
- 03 One mixed set every week, not only before the mocks.

If practice never makes you choose, the exam is the first time you choose.

Study the route before walking it alone.

01 FULL EXAMPLE

every step shown

$$3x + 12 = 24 \rightarrow \text{subtract } 12 \rightarrow 3x = 12 \rightarrow \text{divide by } 3 \rightarrow x = 4$$

02 GAP-FILL

you supply the middle

$$5y - 9 = 16 \rightarrow \text{add } 9 \rightarrow 5y = 25 \rightarrow \text{-----} \rightarrow y = ?$$

03 SOLO

all yours — then the scheme

$$4z + 7 = 31 \rightarrow \text{-----} \rightarrow \text{-----} \rightarrow z = ?$$

HOW A STUDENT RUNS IT

- 01 Read a full solution; explain why each step exists.

- 02 Redo it with the middle steps hidden.

- 03 Then a fresh question, no scaffold — check against the scheme.

Confusion at step two is information, not failure.

Answer the verb, not the topic.

Define

the exact meaning — no story

Explain

the how and the why, in sequence

Contrast

the differences that matter

Evaluate

a judgement, backed by evidence

HOW A STUDENT RUNS IT

- 01 Circle the command word before writing anything.
- 02 Match the shape of the answer to the verb.
- 03 Collect your mismatches; drill them weekly.

In the app: Command-Word Reflex drills the verb until it is automatic.

Find the marks. Name what is missing.

YOUR ANSWER

2 / 3

✓ Defines osmosis correctly

✓ Names the membrane

✗ Missing: the gradient

THE SCHEME

● **definition**
1 mark

● **membrane**
1 mark

● **gradient**
1 mark

HOW A STUDENT RUNS IT

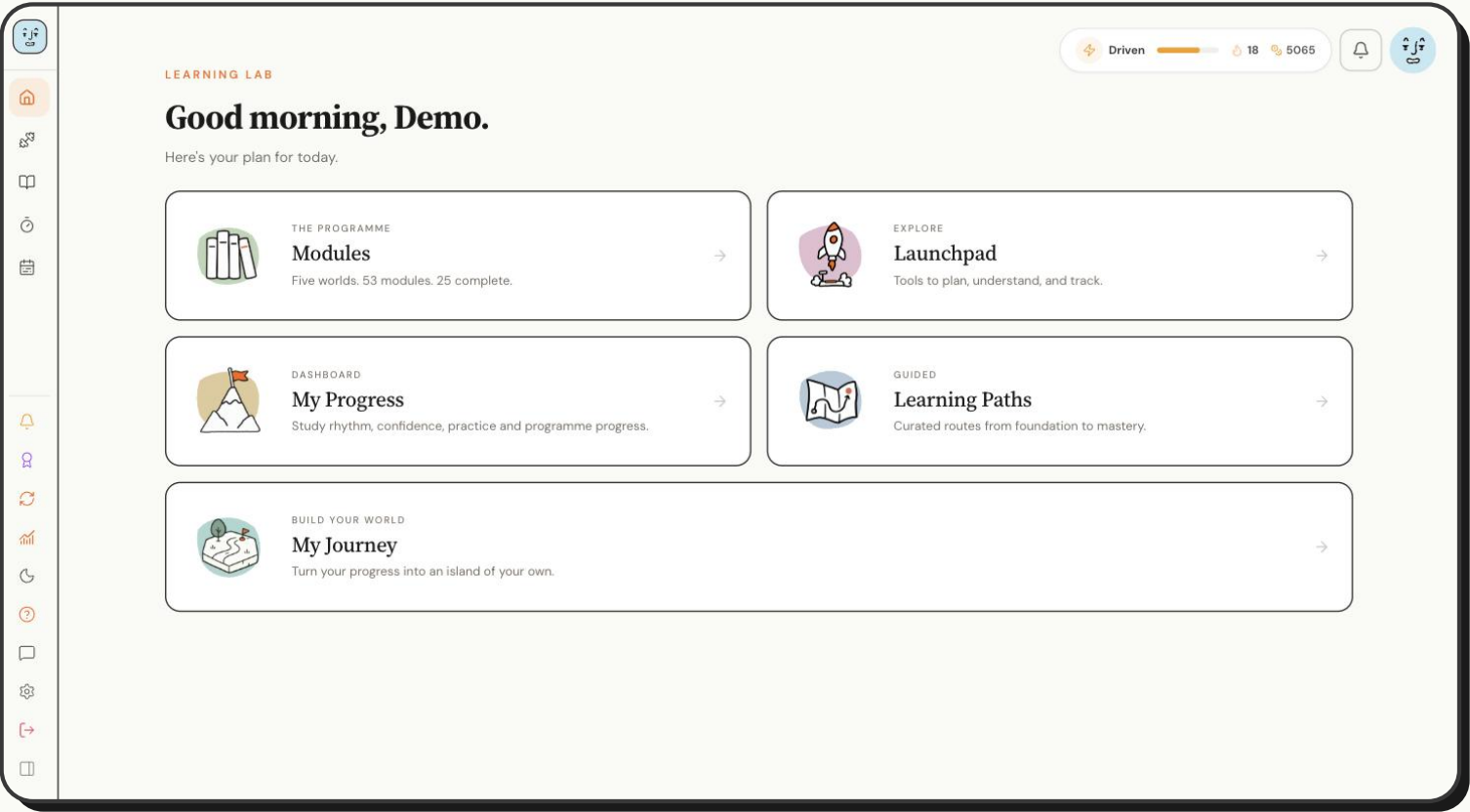
01 Attempt a real question under time.

02 Mark it against the real scheme, point by point.

03 Write one line: what earns the missing mark next time.

In the app: Mark Bank — 552 real questions, marked against the real SEC scheme.

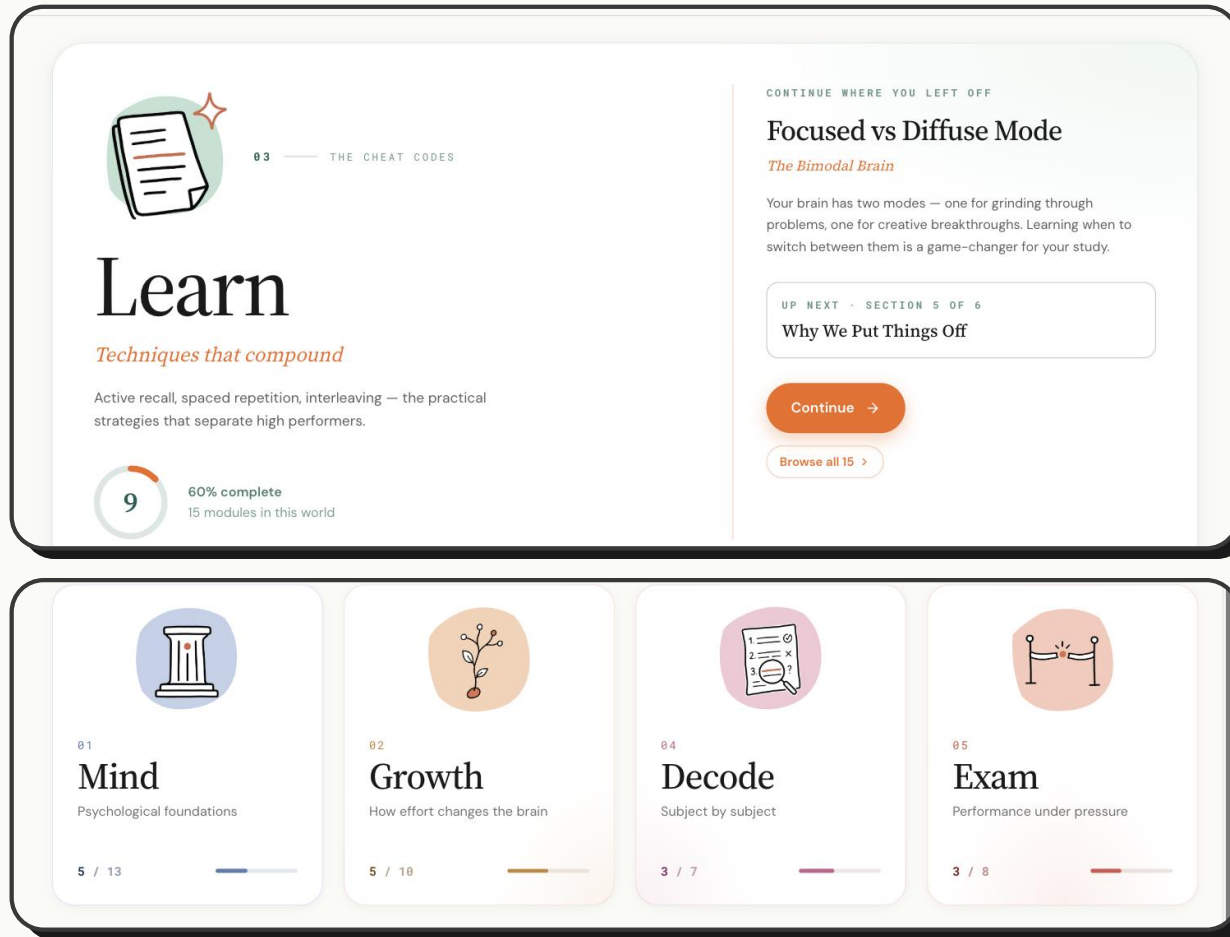
The app should strengthen a human support system.



FIVE PROMISES · FIVE SURFACES

KNOWN	Home one place, one next step
TAUGHT	Modules methods made explicit
PRESENT	My Progress patterns you can discuss
PARTNERED	Launchpad tools chosen for need
FUTURE-READY	My Journey growth becomes a place

Teach the method before asking for independence.



TRANSFER NEEDS ADULT ACTION

- 01 **Explain**
teach one strategy explicitly
- 02 **Model**
use real subject content
- 03 **Choose**
name when and why it fits
- 04 **Fade**
revisit until support can reduce

Completion starts transfer; it does not prove it.

Produce first. Then the real scheme decides.

1 · ATTEMPT FROM MEMORY

< Leave • Biology · HL 1 of 12 this review
552 cards in Biology

BIOLOGY · HIGHER LEVEL · 2025 · Q1(A) 4m

Section A — Question 1. Best five answers from (a) – (f).
Write the general formula for carbohydrates.

THE SCHEME
Answer it in your head, or write it out. Then reveal the scheme and tick off what you had.

Reveal the marking scheme

2 · REVEAL · CHECK · REPAIR

< Leave • Biology · HL 1 of 12 this review
552 cards in Biology

BIOLOGY · HIGHER LEVEL · 2025 · Q1(A) 4m

Section A — Question 1. Best five answers from (a) – (f).
Write the general formula for carbohydrates.

THE SCHEME I had them all

☐ Cx(H2O)y 4m
Printed in the scheme with x and y as subscripts — Cx(H2O)y. The text extraction flattens the subscripts; the subscript form is what the scheme shows.

Marking points quoted from the SEC marking scheme, Biology 2025 Higher Level — © State Examinations Commission.

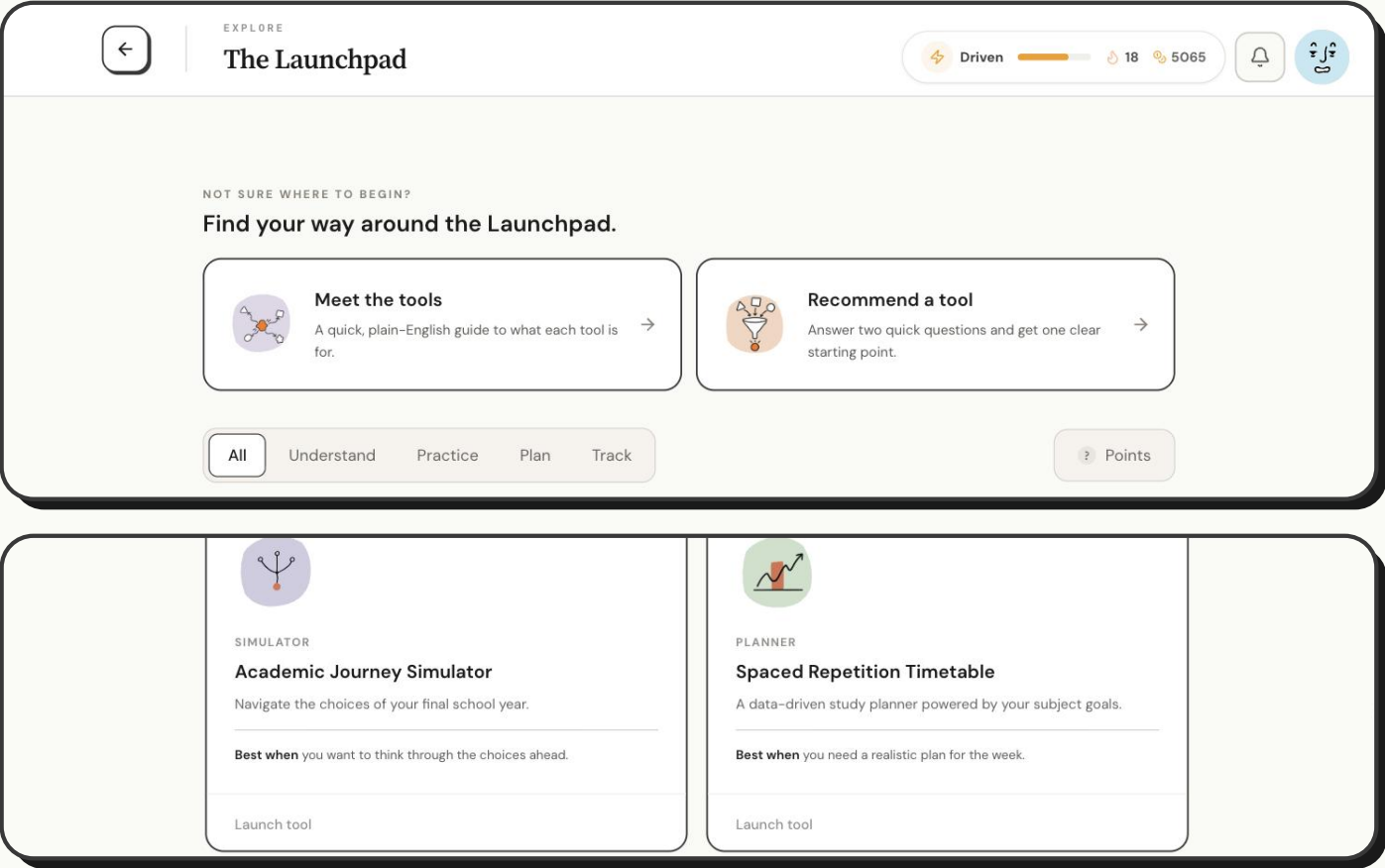
Not claimed yet · 4 marks · cx(h2o)y

You claimed 0 of 4 marks — that looks like Missed it.
You decide. Tap any of the three.

Missed it Shaky Got it

Every question is a real Leaving Certificate question, marked against the real SEC scheme — 552 questions from 2021–2025, then Missed it / Shaky / Got it schedules the return.

One place to understand, practise, plan and track.



UNDERSTAND

Future Finder · Paper Trail · Command-Word Reflex

PRACTISE

Mark Bank · study sessions · exam reps

PLAN

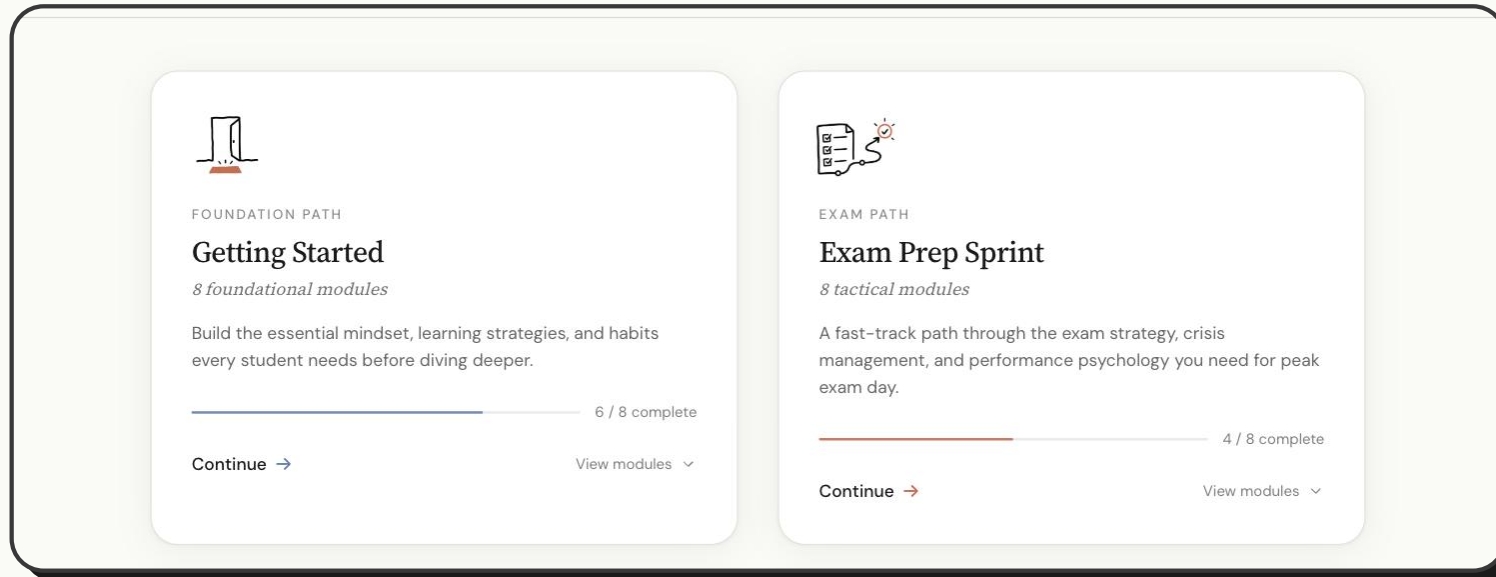
Spaced timetable · War Room · Comeback Engine

TRACK

Journey Simulator · Points Passport · College Compass

Adult role: choose for need · agree the output · review the next move.

The next step stays visible without shrinking ambition.



FOUR LIVE ROUTES

FOUNDATION

stabilise habits and core strategies

EXAM

make tactical preparation explicit

MINDSET

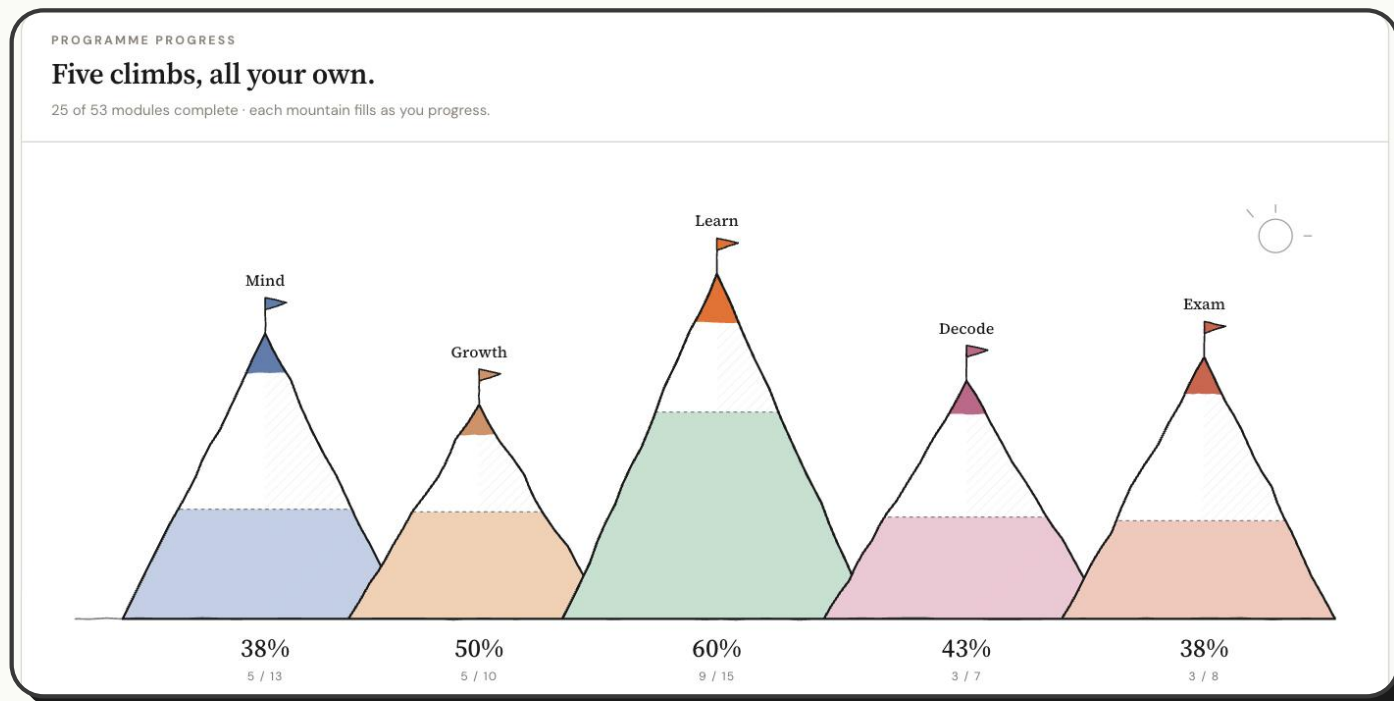
develop resilience and self-knowledge

LEARNING

sequence evidence-based study methods

Sequence support. Never hide prerequisites.

A dashboard should start a conversation — not a verdict.



USE THE FILTERS, THEN ASK

01 What changed?
Compare week, month and year.

02 What helped?
Connect rhythm to method and access.

03 Where is it stuck?
Look for a barrier, not a defect.

04 What happens next?
Name an action and an adult.

Patterns guide support. They do not predict worth.

Let progress become a place the student can shape.



PROGRESS, MADE A PLACE

- 01 **Journey mode**
accumulated effort becomes a place and a story

- 02 **Build mode**
arrange the island; shape what progress looks like

- 03 **Island Shop**
spend earned points on meaningful choice

- 04 **No public ranking**
islands are never compared or displayed

Effort earns it. Choice makes it theirs.

A tool in the routine — never a referee of worth.

01 Choose *for need*

Pick the surface that matches the barrier this week — not the whole app at once.

02 Agree *the output*

Name what the student will produce and show — a session, an attempt, a plan.

03 Review *the next move*

Look at the pattern together and agree one action with one owner.

Patterns guide support. They do not predict worth.

How dependable are the five promises?

01

Known

Can every student name an adult who will notice?

1 · rarely4 · dependable

02

Taught

Does support preserve challenge and future options?

1 · rarely4 · dependable

03

Present

Are patterns acted on before 20 days?

1 · rarely4 · dependable

04

Partnered

Can families reach a person, not only a portal?

1 · rarely4 · dependable

05

Future-ready

Does every student have A, B and C routes?

1 · rarely4 · dependable

Rate the system. Then listen for where students and families would score it differently.

One 90-day test beats a 30-page aspiration.

PROMISE	Which student experience will become more dependable?
FOCUS	For whom, where and when is the gap most visible?
ROUTINE	What will adults do differently, and how often?
OWNER	Who coordinates, supports and follows through?
EARLY SIGNAL	What should move before outcomes move?
REVIEW	What date will the team learn and adapt?

Small enough to implement. Important enough to matter. Specific enough to learn from. Measure support and access — never a student’s private history.

Five moves by Friday.

01	Name	the students at the edge — and the adult who will notice.
02	Contact	one family with a strength before the concern.
03	Audit	one task for hidden vocabulary, steps or assumed support.
04	Map	A, B and C routes with one student.
05	Schedule	the 90-day review before momentum fades.

Momentum is a design choice.

Stop. Start. Protect.



STOP

One routine or phrase that quietly closes a door.



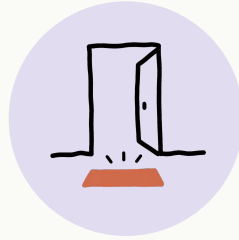
START

One action the school will test for 90 days.



PROTECT

One strength already changing students' odds.



Not every barrier begins in school.

But school decides whether a barrier becomes a ceiling.



Be the school that keeps the door open.

National statistics and policy sources.

CSO	SILC Module on Child Deprivation 2024 cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-silccd/silcmoduleonchilddeprivation2024/
Tusla	Analysis of School Attendance Data 2023/24 tusla.ie/uploads/content/Analysis_of_School_Attendance_Data_2023-24.pdf
Dept. of Education	Retention of the 2018 entry cohort (July 2026); DEIS strategy gov.ie/en/department-of-education/ — retention reports and DEIS Strategy to 2035
OECD	PISA 2022 Results — Ireland country note oecd.org/en/publications/pisa-2022-results-volume-i-and-ii-country-notes_ed6fbcc5-en/ireland_01173012-en.html
HEA	Socio-economic profiles of students, 2021/22–2023/24 hea.ie/statistics/ — widening participation, socio-economic profiles, student profile
ESRI / GUI	Dempsey & McCoy (2025): self-concept, expectations and teacher relationships esri.ie/publications/how-are-childrens-academic-self-concepts-their-parents-expectations-and-their
CSO	Early school leavers — employment and unemployment analyses cso.ie — educational attainment releases; early school leavers, 18–24 outcomes
OECD	Review of Resourcing Schools to Address Educational Disadvantage in Ireland oecd.org/en/publications/oecd-review-of-resourcing-schools-to-address-educational-disadvantage-in-ireland_3433784c-en.ht

Teaching, attendance, trauma and pathways.

NEPS	Continuum of Support and trauma resources gov.ie/en/department-of-education/collections/national-educational-psychological-service-neps-resources-and-publications
EEF	Metacognition and self-regulation; attendance evidence summary educationendowmentfoundation.org.uk/education-evidence/
IES / WWC	Organizing Instruction and Study to Improve Student Learning ies.ed.gov/ncee/wwc/PracticeGuide/1
Dept. of Education	Study routines for the Leaving Certificate gov.ie/en/department-of-education/publications/how-to-create-study-routines-for-the-leaving-certificate-during-the-covid
Campbell review	Effects of trauma-informed approaches in schools pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8356508/
UK Government	Caution on use of ACE screening tools gov.uk/government/publications/trauma-informed-practice-learning-from-experience/
DFHERIS	Education pathways in Ireland gov.ie/en/department-of-further-and-higher-education-research-innovation-and-science/
AccessCollege / SUSI	HEAR eligibility and student grant information accesscollege.ie/hear/how-do-i-apply/eligibility-criteria/